

The Prodigal God: Two Lost Sons and a Reckless Father

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Book 69 of 80

Little Believers Tigrinya Bible Stories

Ages 10-17

Written by Daniel Tesfamariam

Key Verse: Luke 15:24 — "For this son of mine was dead and is alive again; he was lost and is found."

SCENE 1



Jesus had a habit that infuriated religious people: He ate with sinners. Not just tolerated them — He celebrated with them. Tax collectors who cheated the poor. Women with ruined reputations. Men who had abandoned the faith. They all crowded around Jesus, and He welcomed every one of them.

The Pharisees and teachers of the law muttered, "This man welcomes sinners and eats with them." They meant it as an insult. But Jesus heard it as the highest compliment. He was about to tell three stories that would forever reveal the heart of God — and expose the hidden lostness of religious people.

What follows in Luke 15 is not just a parable. It is the gospel in miniature — the most important chapter Jesus ever taught.

Jesus said, "The Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost." He told three parables to show how God looks at sinners. The first was the Parable of the Lost Sheep. A shepherd has a flock of one hundred sheep. One of the sheep goes missing. The shepherd leaves the ninety-nine and goes to look for the one that is lost. When he finds it, he puts it on his shoulders and goes home. He says, "Rejoice, for this sheep was lost and now is found."

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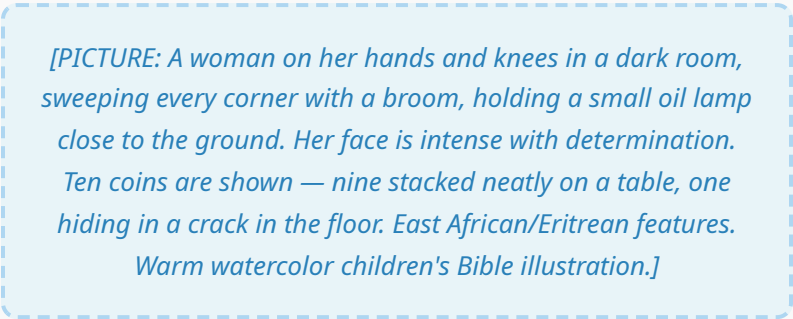
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*(Kabakhatikum hade mi'iti abagi'i zelewo hanti aba ts'igu inte at'fi'u neten tes'an
tish'aten ab gidam hadigu neta zetefeat k'isab zirekba aykeydndo?)*

SCENE 3



"Or suppose a woman has ten silver coins and loses one," Jesus continued. "Doesn't she light a lamp, sweep the house, and search carefully until she finds it?"

These ten coins were likely her marriage dowry — her entire financial security. Losing one wasn't carelessness; it was crisis. So she tears the house apart. She moves every piece of furniture. She sweeps every crack. She doesn't rest until that coin is found.

And when she finds it? She calls her friends and neighbors: "Rejoice with me! I have found my lost coin!" Again, a celebration that seems disproportionate. One coin. A whole party. But this is the point: "In the same way, there is rejoicing in the presence of the angels of God over one sinner who repents." Heaven itself throws a party for one lost person found.

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 neti geza tseriga k'isab trekba bitinqaqe ayitdelin'do?)*

SCENE 4

[PICTURE: A young man with a defiant expression standing before his elderly father in a wealthy household. The son's hand is outstretched, demanding. The father's face shows heartbreak but not anger. Other servants look on in shock. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

Now Jesus tells the main story — the one that would shake everyone listening. "There was a man who had two sons. The younger one said to his father, 'Father, give me my share of the estate.'"

In that culture, this request was unspeakable. You only received your inheritance when your father died. By asking for it now, the younger son was essentially saying: "Father, I wish you were dead. You're worth more to me dead than alive. I want your things, but I don't want YOU."

Every person listening would have gasped. In that society, a father would have been within his rights to strike his son, disown him, or have the community publicly shame him. This wasn't just disrespect — it was the deepest possible rejection of a father's love.

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SCENE 6

[PICTURE: The younger son in a far-off city, surrounded by false friends at lavish parties. He throws gold coins in the air, drinks from expensive cups. The people around him have greedy, opportunistic eyes. Bright but hollow colors. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"Not long after that, the younger son got together all he had, set off for a distant country and there squandered his wealth in wild living."

The far country isn't just a geographical location — it's a spiritual state. It's anywhere we go to escape the Father's presence. The son wanted the father's gifts without the father's company. He wanted blessing without relationship. Freedom without love.

And at first, it felt amazing. Money attracts friends. Wild living feels like freedom. Every party seemed to prove he'd made the right choice. But the "friends" who surrounded him didn't love him — they loved his money. And money always runs out.

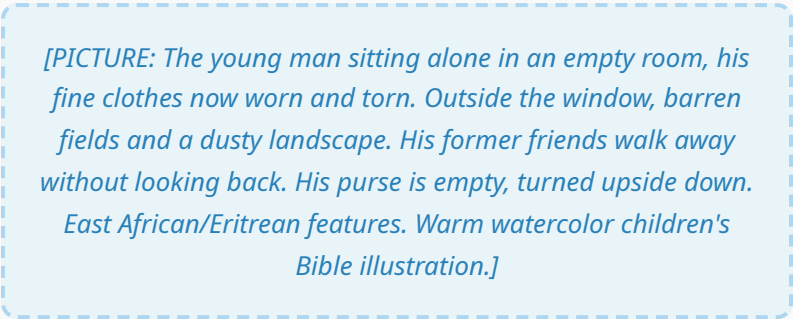
"The younger son took all that was his and went to a far country and there he squandered his money in wild living."

The far country isn't just a geographical location — it's a spiritual state. It's anywhere we go to escape the Father's presence. The son wanted the father's gifts without the father's company. He wanted blessing without relationship. Freedom without love.

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*(Dihri qurub gize iti ni'ishto wedi kulu zelewo akakibu nab rihug hager kede ab'u
dma nibretu ab dur nabra zerege.)*

SCENE 7



"After he had spent everything, there was a severe famine in that whole country, and he began to be in need."

Notice: it wasn't the famine alone that ruined him — it was that he'd already spent everything. When the hard times came, he had no reserves. His "friends" vanished like morning mist. Not one person offered him a meal, a room, or a job. The party was over, and he was utterly alone.

Sin always promises more than it delivers. It promises freedom but delivers slavery. It promises fulfillment but delivers emptiness. It promises community but delivers isolation. Every rebellion against God follows this exact pattern: excitement, emptiness, desperation.

"[The young man] had spent everything, and there was a severe famine in the whole country, and he began to be in need."

Notice: it wasn't the famine alone that ruined him — it was that he'd already spent everything. When the hard times came, he had no reserves. His "friends" vanished like morning mist. Not one person offered him a meal, a room, or a job. The party was over, and he was utterly alone.

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(Kulu mis atfe'a ab ti hager bimlu'u kebid timet metse nisu dma kem zise'an jemere.)

SCENE 8

[PICTURE: The young man, now filthy and starving, crouching among pigs in a muddy pen. He looks at the pig food (carob pods) with desperate hunger. His once fine robe is now rags. His expression shows utter shame and despair. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"So he went and hired himself out to a citizen of that country, who sent him to his fields to feed pigs. He longed to fill his stomach with the pods that the pigs were eating, but no one gave him anything."

For a Jewish young man, this was absolute rock bottom. Pigs were unclean animals — touching them made you ceremonially defiled. He wasn't just poor; he was religiously contaminated. He had fallen so far that he envied animals. He was hungrier than the pigs.

"No one gave him anything." This is the final verdict on the far country. All those people he'd partied with, all those "friends" he'd spent his money on — when he had nothing left to give, they had nothing left for him. The far country always takes everything and gives nothing back.

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*(Nab ri'isu mis metse bele, 'Kindey nay aboy teqots'atseri ziterfom migbi alewo
ane gna abzi bitimet yimewt aleku!')*

SCENE 10

[PICTURE: The young man on the road, rehearsing his speech with hand gestures, practicing what to say. His lips move, memorizing words. In his mind (shown as a thought cloud) he imagines himself as a servant, not a son. The road stretches ahead toward home. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"I will set out and go back to my father and say to him: Father, I have sinned against heaven and against you. I am no longer worthy to be called your son; make me like one of your hired servants."

Notice his plan: he would earn his way back. He would work off his debt. He would become a servant — not a son. He couldn't imagine that his father might simply forgive him and restore him. His speech was carefully rehearsed: confess, declare unworthiness, negotiate a demotion.

This is how we all think about God. We think we must clean ourselves up before coming home. We think we must earn our way back into favor. We think grace must be deserved. But if it must be deserved, it isn't grace — it's wages. And the father in this story doesn't deal in wages.

"I will set out and go back to my father and say to him: Father, I have sinned against heaven and against you. I am no longer worthy to be called your son; make me like one of your hired servants."

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(Tensi'a nab aboy kikeyd'ye kemzi dma kiblo'ye; Abo nismayni n'akani hati'at geyre. Wedka kibhal dro zeybqu'i'ye; kem hade teqots'atsarika gibereni.)

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(Gin gena rihiqu kelo abohu re'ayo. Abzi dew belu. Kem bihaddish anbibwo. Gena rihiqu kelo.)

SCENE 12

[PICTURE: The elderly father RUNNING down the road with his robes hitched up, sandals flying, dignified turban loosened — completely undignified. His face is pure joy, tears streaming down. Servants and villagers look on in shock. The thin son stands frozen on the road, stunned. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"He was filled with compassion for him; he ran to his son, threw his arms around him and kissed him."

The father RUNS. In the ancient Middle East, a dignified older man never ran. Running meant hitching up your robes, exposing your legs — it was considered deeply shameful. Elders walked slowly. They waited for others to come to them. Running was for children and servants.

But this father doesn't care about his dignity. His love is more powerful than his pride. He runs because he cannot wait one more second. He runs because his son is alive. He runs because that's what love does — it doesn't stand on ceremony. It moves. It pursues. It crosses every distance.

He threw his arms around a son who smelled like pigs. He kissed a face that hadn't been washed in months. He embraced a boy who had wished him dead. This is the love of God — undignified, passionate, relentless, unconditional.

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(Birihrähe temel'o; nab wedu goyu haqufu se'amo.)

SCENE 13

[PICTURE: Close-up of the father and son embracing. The son's mouth is open, trying to speak his rehearsed speech, but the father's face is buried in his son's neck, weeping with joy, not even listening yet. The father's arms completely envelop the thin, dirty son. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

The father embraces and kisses his son BEFORE the son can say a single word of his rehearsed confession. The acceptance comes before the repentance is even spoken. The love was never conditional on the apology.

This is grace. It doesn't wait for you to get your words right. It doesn't need to hear your carefully prepared speech. It doesn't make you grovel or prove your sincerity. Grace grabs you while you still stink of the pig pen. Grace holds you before you can earn it.

The son had come prepared to negotiate terms of employment. Instead, he found himself overwhelmed by an embrace he didn't deserve. This is the difference between religion and the gospel: religion says "perform, then be accepted." The gospel says "you are accepted — now watch how that transforms you."

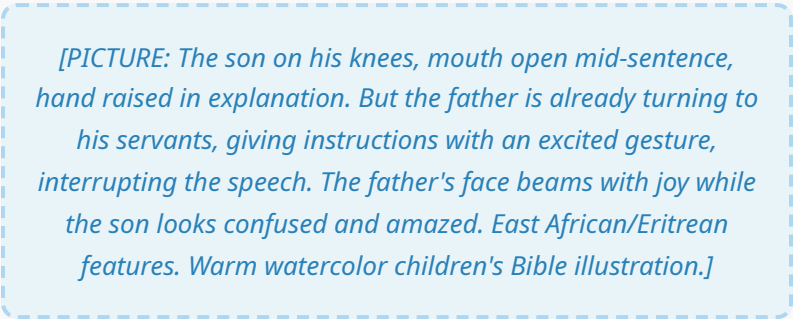
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*(Abo qidmi wedi hanti qal kab zitelemamedo mi'iman keytezerebe yihaqufonin
 yise'amon.)*

SCENE 14



"The son said to him, 'Father, I have sinned against heaven and against you. I am no longer worthy to be called your son.'"

He starts his speech. He gets two sentences in. But notice what's missing: he never gets to say "make me like one of your hired servants." The father cuts him off. He interrupts the negotiation. He refuses to let his son finish the demotion speech.

Why? Because the father will not allow his son to reduce their relationship to an employer-employee transaction. You are not my servant — you are my SON. You cannot earn back what was never earned in the first place. Sonship was never based on your performance. It was always based on my love.

Grace interrupts our attempts to earn it. Every time we try to make deals with God — "I'll be better, I'll try harder, I'll do more" — grace says, "Stop. You're already mine."

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(Wedi belo, 'Abo nismayni n'akani hati'at geyre. Wedka kibhal dro zeybqu'i'ye.)

SCENE 15

[PICTURE: Servants rushing forward with beautiful items: one holds a magnificent robe (the BEST robe), another holds a golden ring on a cushion, a third carries fine leather sandals. The son stands in his rags, arms outstretched as the father directs the servants. Each item symbolizes restored identity. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"But the father said to his servants, 'Quick! Bring the best robe and put it on him. Put a ring on his finger and sandals on his feet.'"

Every item tells a story. The BEST robe — literally the father's own finest garment — meant honored guest status, covering the son's shame and filth completely. The ring was a signet ring — the family seal, meaning full authority restored. He could sign documents, make decisions, act on behalf of the family again. The sandals meant he was a son, not a servant — servants went barefoot; only family members wore shoes.

The father didn't say: "Clean yourself up first." He didn't say: "Prove you've changed." He didn't say: "Let's start with servant status and see how you do." He went straight to FULL restoration. Complete identity. Immediate belonging. This is grace — not partial, not probationary, not conditional. Full. Immediate. Overwhelming.

SCENE 16

[PICTURE: A grand celebration feast. A fattened calf roasting over a fire. Tables laden with food. Musicians playing instruments. People dancing and laughing. The son, now in his new robe and ring, sits at the head table next to his father who cannot stop smiling. Lanterns and decorations everywhere. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"Bring the fattened calf and kill it. Let's have a feast and celebrate!"

The fattened calf was reserved for the most special occasions — a wedding, a visit from the king. It could feed an entire village. This wasn't a quiet family dinner; this was the biggest party the community had ever seen. The father's response to his son's return wasn't measured or cautious — it was extravagant, explosive, overwhelming joy.

There's no probation period. No "let's see if he really means it." No silent treatment. No bringing up the past. Just pure, reckless, disproportionate celebration. The response to repentance isn't punishment reduced — it's a party thrown. This is what heaven looks like when one person comes home to God.

"ἄνθρωπε, ἔλα, ἡμεῖς ἔχομεν τὸν ἀποθνήσκοντα καὶ ζῶντα βοῦν."

ὁ πατήρ αὐτοῦ ἔλαβεν τὸν ἀποθνήσκοντα καὶ ζῶντα βοῦν — ὃν οὐκ ἔδει φάγεσθαι, ἀλλὰ ὃν οὐκ ἔδει φάγεσθαι.

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(Neti zisebhe mirakh amtsi'ikum hireduwo. Nibla'i nihgos!)

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(Miknyatu izi wedey moytu neyru hiji dma bihywet temelisu; tefi'u neyru terekibu dma!)

SCENE 18

[PICTURE: The older brother approaching the house from the fields, still in his work clothes, dusty and sweaty. Through the windows, warm light and shadows of dancing people. Music notes float in the air. His face is twisted with anger and resentment, fists clenched at his sides. A servant tries to explain to him. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"Meanwhile, the older son was in the field. When he came near the house, he heard music and dancing. So he called one of the servants and asked him what was going on."

Now the story shifts — and this is where Jesus's audience of Pharisees should have started sweating. The older brother represents them: the dutiful, obedient, religious ones who never left home. The ones who followed all the rules.

"'Your brother has come,' the servant replied, 'and your father has killed the fattened calf because he has him back safe and sound.' The older brother became angry and refused to go in."

He refused to go in. The party celebrating his brother's return — he boycotted it. His anger wasn't about justice; it was about himself. He wasn't upset that wrong had been done; he was upset that grace had been given to someone he considered undeserving.

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*(Bi'izi iwan iti abi wedi ab grat nebere. Nab geza qeribu muziqan sa'isa'in sim'e.
Hade agelgali tsewi'u intay yikewn alo ilu hatetó.)*

SCENE 19

[PICTURE: The older brother gesturing angrily at the father who has come outside to him. The older son counts on his fingers — years of service, years of obedience. His face is bitter and self-righteous. Behind him through the doorway, the party continues without him. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"But he answered his father, 'Look! All these years I've been slaving for you and never disobeyed your orders.'"

"Slaving." That word reveals everything. The older son didn't see himself as a beloved son — he saw himself as a slave. He had stayed home all those years, but his heart was just as far away as his brother's body had been. He obeyed, but not out of love — out of duty. He stayed, but not because he wanted to be with his father — because he wanted to earn something.

This is the tragedy of religious performance: you can be in the father's house your whole life and never experience the father's love. You can follow every rule perfectly and completely miss the point. The older son was physically home but spiritually in a far country of his own — the far country of self-righteousness.

"... 'Look! All these years I've been slaving for you and never disobeyed your orders.'"

"..." — ...

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(Gin ni'abohu melese, 'Ri'a! Kulen ametat agelgiileka ti'izazka dma fetsime zeytehask.)

SCENE 20

[PICTURE: The older brother pointing accusingly at the house where the party is happening. His mouth open in complaint. He refuses to say "my brother" — pointing at the house and saying "this son of yours." The father's face shows pain at the older son's hardness. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"Yet you never gave me even a young goat so I could celebrate with my friends. But when this son of YOURS who has squandered your property with prostitutes comes home, you kill the fattened calf for him!"

Notice: "this son of YOURS" — not "my brother." He disowns his brother with his words. And notice the entitlement: "you NEVER gave ME." He had lived in a house of abundance and felt deprived. He had access to everything and felt cheated. His self-pity blinded him to the wealth surrounding him.

This is what self-righteousness does: it makes the privileged feel victimized. It makes the blessed feel cursed. It makes people who have everything believe they have nothing. The older brother had his father, his home, his inheritance — and couldn't see any of it because he was too busy keeping score.

"'... I never gave you even a young goat so you could celebrate with your friends. But when this son of yours who has squandered your property with prostitutes comes home, you kill the fattened calf for him!'"

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(Gin mis a'iruktey kihgos may tikewn hanti'wn tel ayhb kannin. Gin natka wedi'zi nibretka mis amenazir zebakenö mis metse neti zisebhe mirakh haridkalu!)

SCENE 21

[PICTURE: The father has come OUTSIDE to the older son, just as he ran to the younger son. He places a gentle hand on the older son's stiff shoulder. The father's face shows the same love and tenderness for both sons. The older son's face is conflicted — anger mixed with being moved. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"So his father went out and pleaded with him."

Don't miss this: the father goes OUT to the older son too. Just as he ran down the road to meet the younger son, he now leaves the party to pursue the older one. Same love. Same initiative. Same pursuit. The father doesn't wait for either son to come to him — he goes to both.

In that culture, for a father to leave his own party and go outside to plead with a disrespectful son was just as undignified as running down a road. The guests would have noticed. The servants would have talked. But this father doesn't care about appearances — he cares about his sons. Both of them.

God pursues the rebellious AND the religious with equal passion. His love chases down the one who ran away AND the one who stayed home with a cold heart. No one is beyond the reach of this pursuing love.

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(Sle'zi abohu wetsi'u lemenö.)

SCENE 22

[PICTURE: The father with open hands gesturing to the whole estate — the fields, the house, the herds. He speaks tenderly to his older son: "Everything I have is yours." The older son's eyes are blinded to the abundance around him, focused only on what his brother received. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"My son,' the father said, 'you are always with me, and everything I have is yours.'"

The father's response is stunning in its gentleness. He doesn't rebuke. He doesn't argue. He simply states the truth: "You've always been with me. Everything is already yours. You could have thrown a party with your friends any time you wanted — you had full access to everything."

The older son's problem wasn't that the father had withheld anything. It was that he never realized what he already had. He was so focused on earning and deserving that he never opened his eyes to the abundance freely available to him. He lived as a slave in a house where he was royalty.

How many of us live like this? We have God's presence, His promises, His love — and we're too busy trying to earn it to enjoy it. We're so focused on performing for God that we miss being with God.

"[...] '00 00 '00 00 0000 00 00 0000 00 000 0000'"

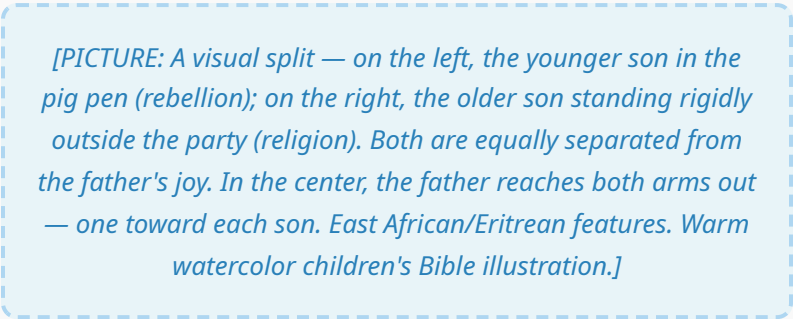
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(Wedey abo bele 'Kulu gize misay ika kulu zeleni dma natka eyu.')

SCENE 23



Here is the revolutionary insight of this parable: there are TWO ways to be lost. Two ways to be separated from the father's love. Two ways to miss the party.

The YOUNGER son's way: open rebellion. Breaking the rules. Running away. Choosing sin over God. This is obvious lostness — everyone can see it, including the lost person themselves.

The OLDER son's way: moral conformity. Keeping the rules. Staying home. Choosing performance over relationship. This is hidden lostness — no one can see it, especially not the lost person themselves.

Both sons wanted the father's things without the father himself. The younger one took them and left. The older one stayed to earn them. But neither one wanted a relationship — they wanted a transaction. And both ended up outside the party, separated from the father's joy.

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*(Nay misale ab'yi mirda'i kemzi'yu: kilte mengedi mitfa'i alo. Kilte mengedi kab
 fiqri abo miflay alo. Kilte mengedi neti be'al mishat alo.)*

SCENE 24

[PICTURE: The father in the center, arms wide open, robe spread wide like wings. Light radiates from him. His generosity is shown as golden light pouring from his hands in all directions. The word "PRODIGAL" written above him in both English and Tigrinya — meaning recklessly extravagant. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

So who is the real "prodigal" in this story? The word "prodigal" doesn't mean "lost" or "rebellious." It means RECKLESSLY EXTRAVAGANT — spending without limit, giving without calculation.

The younger son was prodigal with his father's money. But the FATHER is prodigal with his love. He gives freedom recklessly. He waits faithfully regardless of cost. He runs shamelessly. He forgives instantly. He restores completely. He celebrates extravagantly. He pursues relentlessly — both the rebel and the religious.

The real prodigal is GOD. His love is reckless. His grace is extravagant. His mercy is limitless. His pursuit is relentless. He is the prodigal God — the God who spends His love without calculation, without condition, without limit. He is not a careful, measured God. He is a reckless, passionate, overwhelming Father who will stop at nothing to bring His children home.

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(Ab zanta haqenya "bizey lik'i zi'idil" men'yu? "Prodigal" zibil qal "tifu'i" wey "amatsi" malet aykonen. Bizey lik'i ligsı — bizey deret mi'idal bizey hisab mihab malet'yu.)

SCENE 25

[PICTURE: A modern scene — a teenage boy/girl sitting alone, looking at the viewer/reader directly. Behind them, two paths are visible: one leading to a wild party (the younger son's way), one leading to a church with a rigid, joyless expression (the older son's way). But in front of them, the father stands with open arms, inviting. Light and warmth surround the father. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

So — which son are you? Be honest. Most of us are a mix of both.

Maybe you're the younger son — running from God, chasing things that promise freedom but deliver emptiness. Maybe you're in the far country right now, feeding pigs, wondering how you got here. The father is watching the road for you. He's ready to run.

Or maybe you're the older son — doing all the "right" things but with a cold heart. Going to church, reading your Bible, following the rules — but not out of love. Out of duty. Out of fear. Out of a desire to earn what's already freely given. You're in the father's house, but you've never experienced the father's joy.

Here's the good news for both: the father comes to YOU. He runs to the rebel. He walks out to the religious. His arms are open to both. You don't need to clean up first. You don't need to try

harder. You just need to let the Prodigal God — the recklessly generous Father — love you.

The story ends without telling us what the older brother decided. That's intentional. Jesus left the ending open because He was looking at the Pharisees and asking: "What will YOU choose?" And now He asks you the same: Will you come into the party?

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(Sle'zi — aynay wedi ika? Qinu'i kun. Bizuhatna nay kilteyom hiwsiswas ina.)

The Moral of the Story

English: God is the Prodigal Father — recklessly extravagant in His love for both the rebellious and the self-righteous. There are two ways to be lost: running from God through sin, or staying near God through performance without love. Both miss the Father's heart. But the Father pursues both sons with the same relentless, undignified, overwhelming love. Grace cannot be earned — it can only be received. The party is waiting. Come in.

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Key Verse / 詩篇 138: "For this son of mine was dead and is alive again; he was lost and is found." — Luke 15:24 / "因為我兒已死，又活了，已失，又得了。" — 路加 15:24

Discussion Questions

1. Which son do you relate to more — the younger son who rebels openly, or the older son who obeys outwardly but resents inwardly? Be honest. In what areas of your life do you see yourself acting like either son? Can you identify times when you've wanted God's blessings without wanting a relationship with God Himself?

1. 哪个儿子你更认同——那个公开反叛的 younger son，还是那个表面顺服内心却充满怨恨的 older son？请诚实回答。在你的生活中，你在哪些方面看到自己像任何一个儿子？你能识别出你曾想要上帝的祝福却不想要与上帝建立关系的时候吗？

2. Do you think the older brother is actually MORE lost than the younger brother? Why or why not? The younger son knew he was lost and came home. The older son didn't even realize he was lost. Which is more dangerous — obvious sin or hidden self-righteousness?

2. 你认为大儿子实际上比小儿子更迷失吗？为什么或为什么不？小儿子知道自己迷失了并回家了。大儿子甚至没有意识到自己迷失了。哪一种更危险——明显的罪恶还是隐藏的自以为义？

3. Why is grace so offensive to religious people? Why would the older brother be angry at his father's generosity? Have you ever felt angry or resentful when God seemed to bless someone you thought didn't deserve it? What does that reaction reveal about your own heart?

3. 为什么恩典对宗教人士如此冒犯？为什么大儿子会对父亲的慷慨感到愤怒？你有没有在上帝似乎祝福你认为不配的人时感到愤怒或怨恨？这种反应揭示了你自己内心的什么？

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4. How does the father in this story represent God? List every action the father takes and explain what it reveals about God's character. Why does Jesus emphasize that the father RUNS? What does it mean that God is not a careful, distant God but a passionate, pursuing Father?

4. **האם תוכלו להסביר לנו מהי חשיבות המעורבות?** האם תוכלו להסביר לנו
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5. What does it mean that God "runs" toward us? If God runs toward both the rebellious and the self-righteous, what should our response be? How would your daily life change if you truly believed that God is not keeping score — that He's not a demanding employer but a loving Father who already calls you "son" or "daughter"?

[illegible]

A Prayer of Gratitude for the Prodigal Father

Father God — our Prodigal Father — we come to You amazed by what we've seen today. You are not the distant, stern, score-keeping God we imagined. You are the Father who runs. You are the God who leaves the party to find the one standing alone outside. You are love without limit, grace without condition, mercy without end.

We confess that we are both sons. We have run from You into far countries of our own making — chasing pleasures that promised everything and delivered emptiness. And we have stayed in Your house with cold hearts — doing the "right things" for the wrong reasons, serving You like slaves instead of living like beloved children.

Forgive us for wanting Your blessings without wanting You. Forgive us for treating Your grace as something to earn rather than something to receive. Forgive us for resenting the grace You show to others. Forgive us for keeping score in a kingdom built on gift.

Thank You for being the Prodigal God — recklessly generous with Your love. Thank You that You saw us when we were still a long way off. Thank You that You ran toward us before we could finish our rehearsed speeches. Thank You for the robe of righteousness, the ring of authority, and the sandals of belonging that You place on us — not because we earned them, but because we are Yours.

Help us to come into the party. Help us to stop standing outside — whether in rebellion or in religion — and simply come in and celebrate with You. Teach us to receive what we cannot earn. Teach us to rest in what we cannot achieve. Teach us to be sons and daughters, not servants and slaves.

And Father, for those of us who are still in the far country — give us the courage to come to ourselves and turn our faces toward home. You are watching the road. You are ready to run. We are coming home. In the name of Jesus, the One who told this story to show us Your heart. Amen.

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Little Believers Tigrinya Bible Stories

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